

c. 1299

MARCO POLO NARRATES HIS TRAVELS

The son of a Venetian merchant, Marco Polo travelled with his father along the Silk Road to China. He was received at Kublai Khan's court and stayed in China for 17 years, travelling widely. Returning to Venice in the 1290s, he was made a prisoner during a war with Genoa. While imprisoned he narrated the wonders he had seen to a cellmate, who later published *The Travels of Marco Polo*, a massively influential book.



△ Marco Polo leaves Venice

“I have not told the half of what I saw.”

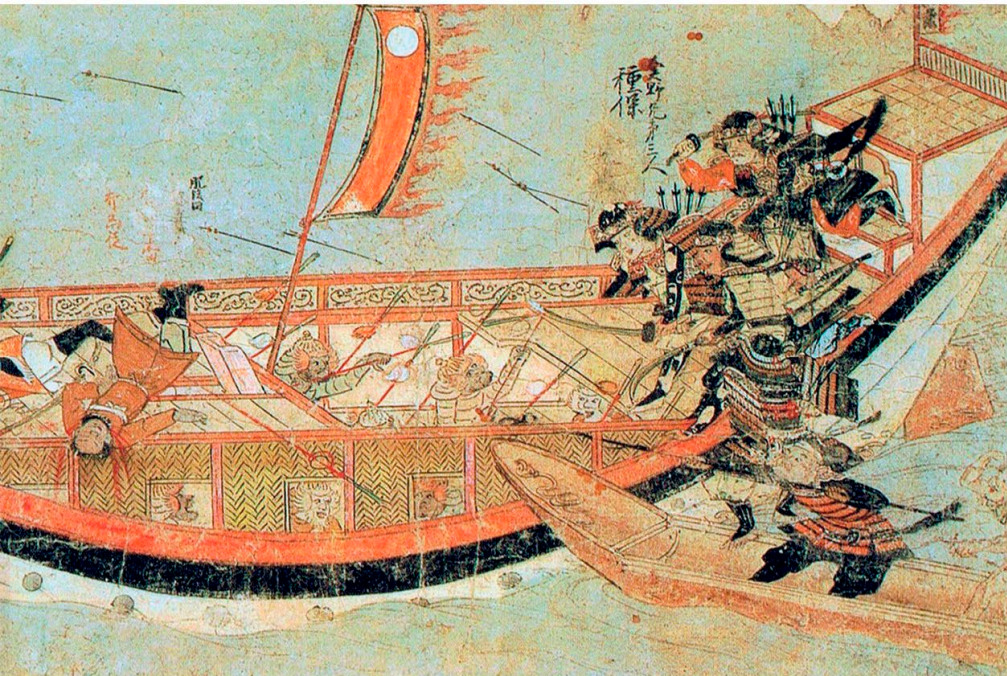
MARCO POLO ON HIS DEATHBED, 1324

1299

1282 The Habsburg family become the rulers of Austria

1290 The Afghan Khalji dynasty seizes power in the Delhi Sultanate

1291 Acre, the last Crusader state, falls to the Mamluks



1281

JAPAN DEFIES THE MONGOLS

Already controlling China and Korea, Kublai Khan sought to add Japan to his conquests. An exploratory expedition in 1274 was followed by a full-scale invasion in 1281. Two fleets sailed from Korea and northern China carrying possibly 150,000 men. The Japanese samurai warriors fiercely resisted initial landings, restricting the Mongols to offshore islands. Then a typhoon, known in Japan as “the divine wind” (“kamikaze”), dispersed the invasion fleet, which took heavy losses. The Mongols made no further attempt to conquer Japan.

◁ The Mongol invasion, Japanese handscroll, c. 1300